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The Ocean Rises

How technology lent a helping hand to relief operations in mainland India, Sri Lanka, Thailand, Indonesia and the Andamans

"The sea—this truth must be confessed—has no generosity. No display of manly qualities—courage, hardihood, endurance, faithfulness—has ever been known to touch its irresponsible consciousness of power."

—Joseph Conrad

Meera Vankipuram

It was almost as if the ocean had decided to make itself heard against the incessant abuse it had been facing for centuries. In one of the worst natural disasters ever, the tsunami that originated near Indonesia and went on to ravage almost 10 countries in south-east Asia, the ocean let us know its might. Any or relief effort thereafter seemed inadequate when

compared with the might of the catastrophe. Amidst all the chaos, even the marvel that is technology could not come to the rescue.

In hindsight, though, a significant number of the casualties could have been avoided had India availed membership of the Tsunami Warning System (TWS) in the Pacific. The TWS monitors seismological and tidal activity in the Pacific Basin and disseminates earthquake and tsunami warning information to its 26 member states within a matter of hours in case of an impending disaster.

Reports now indicate that even without the warning system, India had at least 40 minutes after the

first waves hit the Andaman Islands to send out warning signals to coastal areas.

When disaster struck Indian shores, conventional communication systems were the first casualties. In the face of adversity of mammoth proportions, technology came to the rescue not only in mainland India, but also in Sri Lanka, the Andaman and Nicobar islands, Thailand and Indonesia.

The Web Of Hope

As the water rose, mobile and land-line networks capitulated. Phone calls were not possible. Strangely, though, SMS worked. Those who were not washed away by the waves were able to reach relatives only via SMSes. Bloggers

Photograph DigitalGlobe
Imaging Atul Deshmukh

